Kitchen *& Kettle*

Simple Body Care Guide

CLEAN INGREDIENTS. CLEAR CHOICES.

12 years of trial and error, distilled into what actually works. How to read a soap label, choose products for your skin, and build a simple routine — without the fear-mongering or the 10-step regimen.

Fewer ingredients. Happier skin.

> *This isn't a DIY recipe book. It's a guide to simplifying the products you use, learning what your skin actually needs, and cutting out the clutter. There are a few recipes in here for things genuinely worth making — but the real goal is helping you buy less and choose better.*

> *I don't make any money from mentioning the products in this guide. I have no connection to these companies — no affiliate links, no sponsorships, no free products. I'm just sharing what I've found that actually works.*

You don't need a lot to take care of your skin.

The body care industry wants you to believe you need a different product for every part of your body — a separate cleanser for your face, a different soap for your hands, a special wash for everything else. You don't. Most people do fine with one good soap, a moisturizer they actually use, and clean water.

This guide is about simplifying. Understanding what's actually in your soap. Knowing what to look for — and what to ignore — on a label. And choosing products that work for your skin instead of products that work for a brand's marketing department.

One thing I wish I'd learned sooner: your face might not need soap at all. Warm water and a clean washcloth is often enough — especially in the morning, when you're not removing sunscreen or the day's grime. Save the soap for evenings or days you actually need it. Over-cleansing strips your skin barrier more than it helps.

> *That said — this is the baseline that works for most skin types. Build on it with what makes sense for you. If you love your homemade lotion with lavender essential oil and your skin is happy, I'm not saying to stop. I'm sharing what skin actually needs and the products that won't irritate. Take what works and leave the rest.*

What "clean" means here: fewer ingredients you don't need. Clear labeling you can understand. Products that do the job without irritating your skin. It doesn't mean "chemical-free" — everything is chemicals. Water is a chemical. It means you can read the label and know what you're putting on your body.

Bar soap vs. liquid soap

Bar soaps have two practical advantages. They use less packaging — no plastic pump, no bottle. And they last longer per dollar than most body washes. They're also dry solids, which means they don't need the preservation system that water-based products rely on.

Ingredient-wise, there's no rule that bars are simpler than liquids. Both formats range from bare-bones to overcomplicated. What's more useful than counting ingredients is paying attention to how a product actually interacts with your skin — does it strip, does it leave you tight and dry, does it irritate. Simple bar soaps are easier to find at a regular grocery store — Ivory and Dove Sensitive are on every shelf.

And here's the practical win: you can ditch the plastic pumps. Keep one bar at the sink for hands and face, one in the shower — same bar does it all. No separate hand soap, face wash, and body wash. Less plastic, less counter clutter, less to buy.

> **HONEST NOTE**
>
> *You don't need to switch everything to bar soap overnight. If you love your liquid soap and your skin is happy, keep it. This guide is for people who want to simplify — not for people who already have something that works.*

How to Read a Soap Label

> *Soap labels can be confusing. Here's what actually matters.*

TRUE SOAP VS. DETERGENT BARS

Real soap is made from fats and oils combined with an alkali (lye). The ingredients list will show saponified oils — "sodium cocoate" (coconut oil soap), "sodium olivate" (olive oil soap), "sodium tallowate" (beef fat soap). These are the backbone of a good bar.

Detergent bars — often labeled "beauty bar," "cleansing bar," or "body bar" — use synthetic detergents instead of saponified oils. They're not necessarily bad. Many are formulated to be very gentle. Dove, for example, is a detergent bar and it's one of the mildest cleansers available. The distinction matters more for understanding what you're buying than for judging quality.

COMMON SOAP INGREDIENTS, DECODED

YOU'LL SEE	WHAT IT IS	GOOD OR SKIP?
Sodium tallowate	Saponified beef fat. Classic soap base. Gentle, creamy lather.	Good. The traditional soap fat for centuries.
Sodium cocoate	Saponified coconut oil. Good lather, very cleansing — can be drying alone.	Good in a blend. Too much alone = stripping.
Sodium olivate	Saponified olive oil. Mild, moisturizing, low lather.	Good. Castile soap is 100% olive oil soap.
Sodium palmate	Saponified palm oil. Hardens the bar, adds mild cleansing.	Fine. Look for sustainable palm if that matters to you.

How to Read a Soap Label (continued)

YOU'LL SEE	WHAT IT IS	GOOD OR SKIP?
Glycerin	A humectant that draws moisture to skin. Naturally occurs in soapmaking; some is removed in commercial soap and sold separately.	Good. Soaps that retain glycerin are more moisturizing.
Fragrance / parfum	Can be natural or synthetic — the label won't tell you which. Most common skin irritant in soap.	Skip if you have sensitive skin. "Unscented" or "fragrance-free" are safest.
Sodium lauryl sulfate (SLS)	A detergent that creates foam. Strips oils aggressively.	Skip in face/body products. Fine in hand soap if you don't react.
Titanium dioxide	A white pigment that makes soap opaque and bright white. No cleansing function.	Skip. It's there to make the bar look pretty — doesn't help your skin.

HONEST NOTE

The simplest soaps have the shortest ingredient lists. If a soap has twenty ingredients and half of them are pigments, stabilizers, and preservatives, it's a cosmetic product — not a simple soap. Look for bars with a short ingredient list. Ivory was long the benchmark — a tallow-and-coconut bar with five ingredients — but recently switched to a palm oil base. Still simple, still inexpensive, though tallow purists mourn the change.

Soap Types at a Glance

Four kinds of bar soap, side by side. The right one depends on your skin — not on marketing.

TYPE	EXAMPLES	WHAT'S GOOD ABOUT IT	WATCH OUT FOR
Milled true soap	Ivory	True soap run through industrial rollers that homogenize ingredients and remove unreacted alkali. Short ingredients, no preservatives, minimal packaging. Gentler than you'd expect a true soap to be.	Still higher pH than syndets. Can be drying for very dry skin.
Standard true soap	Grocery store basics, many handmade bars	Simple ingredients — saponified fats and oils. No preservatives needed. Inexpensive and widely available.	Higher pH than skin — more stripping than milled or syndet bars. Coconut-heavy bars are especially drying. No milling means any unreacted alkali stays in the bar.
Syndet bar	Dove Unscented, Cetaphil	Formulated to match skin pH (~5.5). Doesn't disrupt the acid mantle. Gentlest option for eczema, psoriasis, or reactive skin.	Not "natural" — lab-formulated. More ingredients on the label. If natural matters to you, this isn't your bar.

Soap Types at a Glance (continued)

TYPE	EXAMPLES	GOOD	WATCH OUT FOR
Castile	Dr. Bronner's, Kirk's	Pure ingredients — olive oil, lye, water. Plant-based. Excellent household cleaner.	Very high pH (~9–10). Too stripping for daily body use for most people. Must dilute heavily — full strength is almost never right for skin.
Handmade cold-process	Farmers market bars, Etsy	Supports small makers. Retains glycerin. Beautiful ingredients from experienced crafters.	Quality varies widely. Inexperienced maker = uneven lye = irritation. Ask how long they've been soaping and what their process is. A well-made bar is wonderful; a badly made one can hurt.

HONEST NOTE

If you're overwhelmed, start with Dove Unscented or Ivory — both are on every grocery store shelf. Give it two weeks. If your skin is happy, you're done. You don't need to try all five.

Beyond Soap — The Simple Routine

THE ONLY THREE THINGS MOST PEOPLE NEED

1. **A good soap.** One bar. Use it on your body. Your face might want something gentler — or it might be fine with the same bar. Try it and see.
2. **A moisturizer you'll actually use.** The best moisturizer is the one you reach for consistently. A basic unscented lotion (Cetaphil, CeraVe, Vanicream) covers most needs. Tallow balm is another option — rendered beef fat whipped into a moisturizer, very similar to the oils our own skin produces. If you have a jar of something expensive that you use twice a month, it's doing less for your skin than a drugstore lotion you use every day.
3. **Sun protection.** This is the one skincare product with decades of research behind it. A daily moisturizer with SPF 30 prevents more skin damage than any expensive serum or treatment. If you do nothing else for your skin, do this.

IF YOU WANT TO DO A LITTLE MORE

These two have actual research behind them — they're not marketing. An **antioxidant serum** in the morning under your sunscreen (vitamin C is the most studied). And a **retinol serum** two or three nights a week after cleansing. That's it. You don't need a seven-step routine. I use The Ordinary — they're inexpensive, simple formulations, and widely available.

DAILY ROUTINE

Morning

- Rinse face with warm water — no cleanser needed for most people in the morning
- Apply antioxidant serum
- Apply sunscreen — reapply throughout the day

Evening

- Wash face — evening is when it counts, removing sunscreen and the day's build-up
- Retinol serum — 3 nights a week
- PM moisturizer

What Each Product Actually Does

> *Soap gets all the attention in this guide. Here's what the rest of the products are doing for your skin — and which ones your body genuinely needs.*

MOISTURIZER

After cleansing, your skin needs moisture put back. Soap removes dirt and oil — including some of the oils your skin produces to protect itself. A moisturizer replaces what was washed away so your skin barrier stays intact.

But "moisturizer" is a catch-all word that lumps together two different jobs. Understanding which is which will save you money and help you pick the right product for your skin.

Occlusives seal moisture in. They don't add moisture — they create a barrier that stops water from evaporating out of your skin. This is occlusion, and it's one of the oldest skincare techniques we have. Think of it as putting a lid on a pot of water: the water stays in, but the lid isn't adding any. Petrolatum (Vaseline) is the gold standard — it blocks about 99% of water loss. Tallow and beeswax work the same way. If you put pure Vaseline on dry skin, you've sealed in… dryness. That's why occlusives work best on damp skin, or layered over something that actually adds moisture first.

Humectants add moisture. These pull water from the air and from the deeper layers of your skin into the surface. Glycerin and hyaluronic acid are the most common. This is what people usually mean by "moisturizer" — something that actually hydrates. Hyaluronic acid can hold up to 1,000 times its weight in water, which is why a single drop of a hyaluronic acid serum on damp skin can hydrate your whole face.

Emollients smooth the surface. These fill in the microscopic cracks between skin cells so your skin feels soft instead of rough. Jojoba oil, shea butter, coconut oil, and squalane are all emollients. Most plant oils fall into this category — they condition the skin but don't seal as aggressively as a true occlusive.

MOISTURIZER (CONTINUED)

What this means in practice: If your skin feels tight and dry, you need a humectant — something that actually adds water. If your moisturizer seems to disappear in an hour, you need an occlusive on top to seal it in. Most good products contain at least two of the three. CeraVe cream, for example, has humectants (glycerin) plus occlusives (petrolatum) plus emollients (ceramides). Tallow balm is primarily an occlusive with natural emollients — great as a final layer, better if your skin is already damp when you apply it. A hyaluronic acid serum is a pure humectant — it adds water but needs an occlusive over it to keep that water from evaporating right back out.

You don't need a separate face cream and body lotion. One unscented product usually does both jobs. The best moisturizer is the one you'll actually reach for — an expensive jar you use twice a month does less for your skin than a drugstore lotion you use every day.

SUNSCREEN

Sun damage is cumulative and mostly invisible until it isn't. UVB rays burn the surface; UVA rays go deeper and break down collagen over time. Both contribute to skin cancer. This isn't marketing — it's one of the most settled findings in dermatology, backed by decades of research.

SPF 30 blocks about 97% of UVB rays when applied properly. But SPF only measures UVB protection — it tells you nothing about UVA. That's what "broad spectrum" means on the label: the sunscreen protects against both. Without broad spectrum, you're blocking the burn but not the deeper damage. Look for both: SPF 30 or higher, and "broad spectrum" on the front. Most people apply too little — a nickel-sized dollop for your face, a shot glass worth for your body.

If you do nothing else for your skin, do this. Sun protection prevents more damage than any serum, treatment, or expensive cream ever will. Reapply if you're outside for hours. Your future skin will thank you — and unlike most skincare promises, this one has the data to back it up.

ANTIOXIDANT SERUM (VITAMIN C)

Your skin is under constant oxidative stress. Pollution, UV exposure, even normal metabolism produces free radicals — unstable molecules that damage collagen and cause uneven pigmentation over time. Antioxidants neutralize those free radicals before they can do harm.

Vitamin C (ascorbic acid) is the most studied topical antioxidant. There's solid evidence it protects against UV-induced damage when used under sunscreen — it doesn't replace sunscreen, but it adds a second layer of defense. It also helps brighten dark spots and even out skin tone over time.

It's not essential. Sunscreen does the heavy lifting. But vitamin C is the one serum with enough research behind it to earn a place in a simple routine. Apply in the morning, under moisturizer and sunscreen. Look for a formula in dark or opaque packaging — vitamin C degrades in light.

RETINOL

Retinol is vitamin A in a form your skin can use. It speeds up cell turnover — the process by which your skin sheds old cells and makes new ones. This process slows with age. Retinol restores some of that pace, which is why it helps with fine lines, uneven texture, and occasional breakouts.

The catch: it's not instant and it's not subtle. Your skin may get dry, flaky, or irritated for the first few weeks while it adjusts. Start with a low concentration (0.25% or 0.3%) two nights a week, and build up slowly over months. More is not better — a pea-sized amount is enough for your whole face.

Never use retinol in the morning. It breaks down in sunlight and makes your skin more sun-sensitive. This is a long game — results take months, not days. But among anti-aging ingredients, retinol has some of the strongest evidence behind it. If you're going to add one active to your routine beyond sunscreen, this is the one.

Try sandwiching if your skin reacts. If retinol (or any active serum) feels too harsh applied directly to clean skin, buffer it with moisturizer: a thin layer of moisturizer first, then the serum, then more moisturizer on top. The moisturizer doesn't block the active — it just slows the absorption so your skin gets the benefit without the sting. This also works for vitamin C in the morning if your skin is reactive. Start with the sandwich, then try the serum directly once your skin adjusts.

Body Care Reality Filter: What's Worth Making (and What Isn't)

I know how hard it is to let go. As a DIY-er you want to make everything — and social media doesn't help. You watch someone's home recipe reel and feel like you should be doing that too. But here's what I learned when I started researching what actually works and is safe for your skin: some recipes aren't worth your time. Some are genuinely better from a lab. And some are exactly where your energy belongs.

This isn't about natural versus synthetic. It's about skin-barrier-compatible chemistry versus traditional soap chemistry — and about being honest with how much time you actually have.

MAKE THESE — THEY'RE WORTH IT

- **Tallow balm.** Rendered beef fat whipped into a moisturizer. It's remarkably close to the oils your own skin produces — tallow, a little coconut oil for spreadability, and if you want, the tiniest drop of lavender essential oil to cut any lingering scent (skip this if your skin is sensitive). It does what a $40 cream does for pennies.
- **Infused oils.** Calendula in jojoba oil. Plantain in jojoba oil. Lavender in jojoba oil. You're harvesting and drying herbs you grew or gathered, then extracting their medicine into a carrier oil. I use jojoba — it's light, absorbs fast, and doesn't have the heavy smell olive oil can carry. This is slow, simple, and deeply satisfying — and the quality of something you made yourself from plants you know is real.
- **Salves.** Take your infused oils, add a little beeswax, pour into a tin. Now you have a wound salve, a chest rub, a moisturizing balm. These are medicine. This is where your free time is well spent.
- **Deodorant.** A simple paste of coconut oil, shea butter, baking soda, and arrowroot powder works for a lot of people. It takes five minutes to make. If your skin tolerates baking soda, this is an easy win. And when you're tired or out of ingredients? Schmidt's lavender sage is the backup — the only store-bought deodorant that's ever worked for me.

Body Care Reality Filter (continued)

SUPPORT THE GOOD GUYS — BUY THESE

I hit a wall trying to make every product we use. And when I really looked at it, I realized making my own soap still meant buying a big plastic jug of lye shipped to my house — while a simple bar in cardboard was already sitting at the grocery store I was driving to anyway.

- **Soap.** Dove Unscented, Ivory, or a good local bar. The most compatible formula for your skin has already been figured out. The packaging is cardboard. No more ordering plastic bottles of ingredients.
- **Sunscreen.** This is the one product where consistency and proven protection genuinely matter. Leave SPF formulation to the labs — it's regulated for a reason.
- **Lotion.** Mainly to give yourself a break. A basic unscented lotion from Cetaphil or CeraVe works. You don't need to emulsify your own.
- **SPF chapstick.** Your lips burn too. Grab one at the drugstore.
- **Deodorant.** If the DIY paste isn't for you — or you're just tired and out of ingredients — Schmidt's is the closest thing to homemade I've found. The lavender sage one is what I reach for. It's the only commercial deodorant that's actually worked for me.
- **Toothpaste & mouthwash.** Your enamel is not the place to experiment. Fluoride in drinking water is a fair debate. Fluoride in toothpaste is a different thing entirely — it's topical, you spit it out, and decades of research show it strengthens enamel and prevents cavities. The "remineralizing" toothpaste recipes circulating online — usually baking soda and coconut oil — can't replace what a basic tube of Pepsodent does. This is where greenwashing gets genuinely harmful.
- **Shampoo & conditioner.** Free & clear is the move here. CeraVe and Vanicream both make a liquid shampoo. For conditioner, I skip it entirely — a single drop of jojoba oil rubbed between my palms and worked into the ends after showering does the job. There are a few free & clear shampoo bars on the market, but at the time of writing the reviews are mixed. If someone nails the bar, I'll switch.

HONEST NOTE

I spent too much money on ingredients for recipes that didn't work. I made dish detergent that was worse than the $3 bottle. I tried toothpaste recipes that made me cringe. Meanwhile, there are businesses that already care about making free & clear products — and they've figured it out. Relieving myself of the pressure to DIY everything gave me back my evenings. I could meal prep with whole ingredients instead of rushing to mix up hand soap. I could nurse my chicken's broken foot instead of researching emulsifiers. Our time is precious and our minds are tired. Let yourself buy the soap.

WHO'S TELLING YOU TO MAKE EVERYTHING?

A lot of the pressure comes from social media. But pay attention to who's giving the advice. Many of those influencers don't report to an office forty hours a week — they have the time to experiment, film, and troubleshoot. Some of their recipes are genuinely inferior to lab-made products (homemade dish detergent, I'm looking at you). And some are pushing greenwashing that sounds good but doesn't hold up — like "remineralizing" toothpaste made from baking soda, which can actually be abrasive to enamel.

The truth is, we all want a simpler life. We want to get back to basics and stop being fed junk — metaphorically and literally. I absolutely encourage you to make the things you feel passionate about. But remember there are others who care too — the businesses who already make the fragrance-free, dye-free, simple-ingredient products. You don't have to do it all.

What I hope this guide gives you is mental relief. Permission to buy the toothpaste. A short list of products that won't irritate your skin. And more time for the things that actually matter — whole meals, your garden, your animals, your rest.

A simple whole food guide (that actually tastes amazing) is coming soon.

Here's the balance that actually worked for me: keep your skincare pantry stocked with free & clear baseline products — the unscented soap, the drugstore moisturizer, the Pepsodent. Then put your real effort into making the things that function like medicine for your body. Salves. Infused oils. Bath soaks. These are the recipes that earn their keep.

RECIPES

Tallow Balm

Tallow is rendered beef fat — and it's remarkably similar to the oils your own skin produces (sebum). That's why it absorbs so well instead of sitting on top like petrolatum. Your skin recognizes it.

It's rich in vitamins A, D, E, and K — all fat-soluble vitamins your skin uses. Its fatty acid profile is closer to human skin oil than most plant oils, which means it integrates with your skin barrier rather than just coating it. A whipped tallow balm — just tallow plus a little coconut oil for spreadability — replaces a moisturizer, a night cream, and a lip balm in one jar.

People with eczema and psoriasis often find tallow calms their skin when commercial creams don't, possibly because it contains conjugated linoleic acid, which has anti-inflammatory properties. It costs pennies to make. The tradeoff: you have to render the fat, whip it, and store it. For some people, that's a satisfying ritual. For others, a $12 tub of Cetaphil is the better choice. Both are valid.

HOW TO MAKE IT

A whipped moisturizer that costs pennies and replaces a $40 face cream. Three ingredients. No emulsifiers.

What you need: Beef fat trimmings (ask your butcher — they often give them away), a little coconut oil for spreadability, a clean jar. Optional: the tiniest drop of lavender essential oil to cut any lingering scent — skip if your skin is sensitive.

Make it:

- Render the tallow: Cut fat into small pieces. Put in a crock pot on low or a dutch oven at 200°F. Let it go 4–6 hours until the fat is liquid and the cracklings are golden. Strain through cheesecloth into a clean jar.
- Let the strained tallow cool until it's solid but still soft — like room-temperature butter.
- Whip with a hand mixer for 2–3 minutes until creamy and white. Add a spoonful of coconut oil while whipping for a softer, more spreadable balm. If using lavender, add a single drop now.
- Scoop into a jar. Use on face, hands, elbows — anywhere. A little goes a long way.

Tallow Balm (continued)

> *Tallow is remarkably close to the oils your own skin produces. That's why it absorbs so well and doesn't sit on top like petrolatum. Keeps 6+ months at room temperature, longer in the fridge.*

> ***Hack:*** *Skip the rendering. Some supermarkets carry jars of already-rendered cooking tallow in the baking or international aisle. Let it come to room temperature, whip it, and add a little coconut oil for spreadability. The tiniest drop of lavender essential oil cuts any lingering meat smell — skip if your skin is sensitive.*

> ***Hack:*** *Buy tallow-based sunscreen. It's already rendered, and because the minerals that provide the SPF are the main event, there's no tallow scent at all. I've found this to be the best option for sensitive skin if you want to use tallow — all the skin-compatibility benefits, none of the rendering work.*

Infused Oils

Plant oils carry more than moisture. Many herbs contain compounds — anti-inflammatory, antimicrobial, skin-soothing — that extract into oil over time. This is one of the oldest forms of medicine, and it still works.

Calendula reduces redness and speeds skin healing. **Plantain** (the leafy weed, not the banana) draws out splinters and calms insect bites. **Lavender** relaxes and has mild antimicrobial properties. **Chamomile** soothes sensitive, reactive skin. Each herb brings something different, and you can blend them to match what your skin needs.

The process is almost entirely passive: dried herbs in a jar, covered with oil, left on a sunny windowsill for a month. Strain, bottle, label. What you get is a custom skincare oil that a store can't replicate — because you chose the herbs, you know when they were harvested, and you made it in small batches with nothing added. Use infused oils straight on damp skin after a shower, or as the base for salves.

Unlike essential oils — which are concentrated, volatile, and a potential skin irritant — infused oils are gentle extractions. You're steeping whole herbs in a carrier oil, not distilling their most potent compounds. Still, any plant can irritate the wrong person. Patch test a new herb on your inner arm before committing to a full jar.

Infused Oils (continued)

HOW TO MAKE THEM

Herbal medicine you make on a windowsill. These are the foundation of salves — and you can use them straight on your skin too.

What you need: Dried herbs (calendula, plantain, lavender, chamomile — pick one or blend), a carrier oil (I use jojoba — it's light and absorbs fast; sweet almond and fractionated coconut oil also work well; olive oil is traditional but I stopped using it for skincare years ago — too thick and the smell competes with your herbs), a clean jar with a tight lid, cheesecloth for straining.

Make it:

- **Use dried herbs only.** Fresh herbs contain water, and water in oil = mold. If you're harvesting your own, dry them completely first — hang bundles in a dark, airy spot until they crumble.
- Fill a clean jar about ⅓ full with dried herb. Don't pack it tight — leave room for the oil to circulate.
- Pour oil over the herbs until they're completely submerged by at least an inch. Cap tightly and place in a warm spot — a sunny windowsill works. Steep for 4–6 weeks, shaking gently when you remember.
- Strain through cheesecloth into a dark glass bottle. Label with the herb and date. Store in a cool, dark place.

Infused Oils (continued)

> *Good starter herbs: **Calendula** for skin healing and gentle baby care. **Plantain** for bug bites and scrapes. **Lavender** for calming and a scent you actually want. **Chamomile** for sensitive, reactive skin. You can also blend — calendula + lavender is a favorite.*

> *And if you don't want to infuse at all? Plain jojoba oil or coconut oil makes an excellent body moisturizer straight from the bottle. It doesn't get simpler than that.*

Salves

A salve is an infused oil solidified with beeswax so it stays where you put it. Where an oil drips and spreads, a salve sits on the skin and creates a protective seal. This is occlusion — one of the oldest wound-care techniques we have — and it works by keeping moisture in and irritants out while the herb compounds do their work.

Beeswax isn't just a thickener. It has its own mild anti-inflammatory and antibacterial properties, and it creates a breathable barrier — it seals without suffocating the skin. A calendula salve on dry, cracked hands works better than most lotions because it doesn't evaporate or rub off. A plantain salve on a bug bite creates a physical barrier while the herb draws out the irritant.

Salves keep for years without preservatives. No water means no spoilage. One batch of infused oil can become multiple salves — pour off a portion for calendula salve, add a little more beeswax for a firmer chest rub, leave some soft for a hand balm. They're endlessly adaptable, and they cost almost nothing once you have the infused oil.

HOW TO MAKE THEM

Take your infused oil, add beeswax, and you have a solid balm that travels and keeps for years. This is real medicine in a tin.

What you need: 1 cup infused oil, about 1 oz beeswax (pastilles are easiest to measure), small tins or jars. That's it.

Make it:

- Pour your infused oil into a small pot or a heatproof jar set in a pan of water (double-boiler style). Warm gently on low heat — you're not cooking it, just warming enough to melt wax.
- Add beeswax and stir until fully melted. For a firmer salve, add a little more wax. For a softer one, use a little less. 1 oz per cup of oil is the starting point.
- Pour into clean tins or jars. Let cool completely before putting the lids on — condensation is the enemy.
- Label with the herbs used and the date. Store in a cool place.

> *Uses: **Calendula salve** — scrapes, rashes, dry hands. **Plantain salve** — bug bites, splinters, minor wounds. **Lavender salve** — calming chest rub before bed, temples for tension. One infused oil can become multiple salves — just pour the oil off into smaller batches and add beeswax to each.*

Deodorant

Your sweat doesn't smell. The bacteria that live on your skin break sweat down into compounds that do. Deodorant works by making the environment less hospitable to those bacteria — baking soda raises the pH, arrowroot powder absorbs moisture, and coconut oil is mildly antimicrobial. It handles odor, not wetness.

This is different from antiperspirant, which uses aluminum compounds to physically block sweat glands. That's not inherently bad — the aluminum scare isn't well-supported by research — but some people prefer not to block a natural process. A simple paste deodorant is for people who are fine sweating and just don't want to smell.

If you've been using antiperspirant for years, expect a transition period. Your underarm bacteria need time to rebalance — the species that thrive in an aluminum-blocked environment are different from the ones that live on open skin. Give it two weeks. You may feel sweatier during the shift, then your body adjusts. If the baking soda irritates, swap it for more arrowroot or try magnesium hydroxide instead.

HOW TO MAKE IT

A simple paste that takes five minutes. No plastic tube, no aluminum, no propylene glycol. Your armpits may need a transition period from commercial antiperspirant — give it two weeks.

What you need: ¼ cup coconut oil, 2 tablespoons shea butter, ¼ cup baking soda, ¼ cup arrowroot powder. A small jar. Optional: a few drops of lavender or tea tree essential oil.

Make it:

- Gently warm the coconut oil and shea butter together just until soft — not fully melted. You want a paste consistency, not a liquid.
- Mix in baking soda and arrowroot powder. Stir until smooth and combined. Add a few drops of essential oil if you want a scent.
- Scoop into a small jar. Apply a pea-sized amount with your fingertips to clean underarms.

> ***Important:*** *Baking soda can irritate some people's underarms — especially after shaving. If you get redness or burning, swap the baking soda for more arrowroot, or try magnesium hydroxide instead. This recipe is a starting point, not a prescription. Listen to your skin.*

Bath Salts

Magnesium through the skin, herbs for what your body needs. This is medicine you soak in — and it takes five minutes to put together.

What you need: 2 cups Epsom salts, ¼ cup Dead Sea salts (optional), a handful of dried herbs (lavender, chamomile, calendula — pick what your body needs), a tablespoon of jojoba oil. A jar with a tight lid.

Make it:

- Mix the salts and dried herbs together in a bowl.
- Add the jojoba oil last, stirring until evenly distributed.
- Scoop into a jar. Label with the herbs and date.
- Add ¼ to ½ cup to a warm bath. Soak.

> *Skip the oil if you prefer, but it keeps the salts from drying out your skin. Dead Sea salts add minerals but plain Epsom works beautifully on its own. Pair with an infused oil applied after the bath for deep moisture.*

> ***Add-ins:*** *¼ cup colloidal oatmeal makes this incredibly soothing for eczema, poison ivy, or any angry skin — just grind plain oats to a fine powder in a blender. Or try ¼ cup powdered milk for a gentle lactic-acid soften. Both mix right in with the salts.*

Quick Reference

> *The short version: what to look for, what to skip, what to try.*

Label red flags

- "Fragrance" or "parfum" — most common skin irritant. Choose unscented if you react.
- More than 10 ingredients in a simple bar soap — it's a cosmetic, not a soap.
- "Antibacterial" — the FDA found no evidence antibacterial soaps work better than plain soap and water. Skip triclosan.
- Titanium dioxide, mica, pigments — decoration, not function.

Good starting points

- **If you want the simplest option:** Ivory bar soap. Still one of the shortest ingredient lists on the shelf.
- **If you have sensitive skin:** Dove Unscented. It's a detergent bar and that's why it's gentle.
- **If you want plant-based:** Look for olive-oil castile, dilute it, and patch test first.
- **If you want to support small makers:** Farmers market cold-process bars — ask what's in them.

The simple routine

- **Morning:** Rinse face with warm water (soap optional). Antioxidant serum (if using). Moisturizer + SPF 30.
- **Shower:** One bar of soap. Wash hair with free & clear shampoo like CeraVe.
- **After shower:** Moisturize while skin is damp. Drop of jojoba oil on hair ends.
- **Night:** Wash face with water or mild cleanser. Retinol serum (2–3× a week). Moisturize.
- **Hands:** Wash with whatever bar is at the sink. Moisturize with free & clear cream.

My Notes

SOAPS I'VE TRIED AND LIKED

SOAPS THAT DIDN'T WORK FOR ME

MY DAILY MOISTURIZER

SKIN NOTES BY SEASON

A note on body care

Your skin is an organ. It doesn't need a ten-step routine or a shelf full of products. It needs protection from the sun, moisture when it's dry, and gentle cleansing that doesn't strip its natural barrier.

The body care industry profits from making you feel like your skin is a problem to be solved. It isn't. Most skin is healthy skin doing its job. A good soap, a moisturizer you actually use, and sunscreen — that's all most people need.

If a product promises to fix what isn't broken, you don't need it. If a routine makes you feel anxious instead of cared for, simplify it. Good body care should feel like nourishment, not like solving a puzzle.

Simple care, simply made

Your skin doesn't need a ten-step routine. A few good ingredients, some basic techniques, and the confidence to ignore the rest of the beauty aisle — that's the whole system. What you put on your body should be as straightforward as what you put in it.

Works because it works.

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